DBQ Point Guide 6: Complexity

Oct 28, 2026 · @CJ DeRuyter

What the rubric requires

The complexity point (Row D, 1 pt) goes to an essay that shows a complex understanding of the prompt's development through sophisticated argument **or** effective use of evidence. There are seven ways to earn it, and students only need one.

Route	Path	What it takes
Argument	Multiple perspectives or themes	Explain how different groups saw it, or how it played out politically, economically, socially
Argument	Multiple causes, effects, similarities, or changes	At least two, each explained
Argument	Both sides of a pair	Cause *and* effect, similarity *and* difference, or continuity *and* change
Argument	Connections across time or place	A developed comparison to another period or region that sharpens the argument
Evidence	Seven documents	All seven used to support an argument (one or two can be weaker)
Evidence	Four documents sourced	HIPP explained and tied to the argument for four documents
Evidence	Documents + outside evidence for perspectives	Using both to show how different groups saw the issue

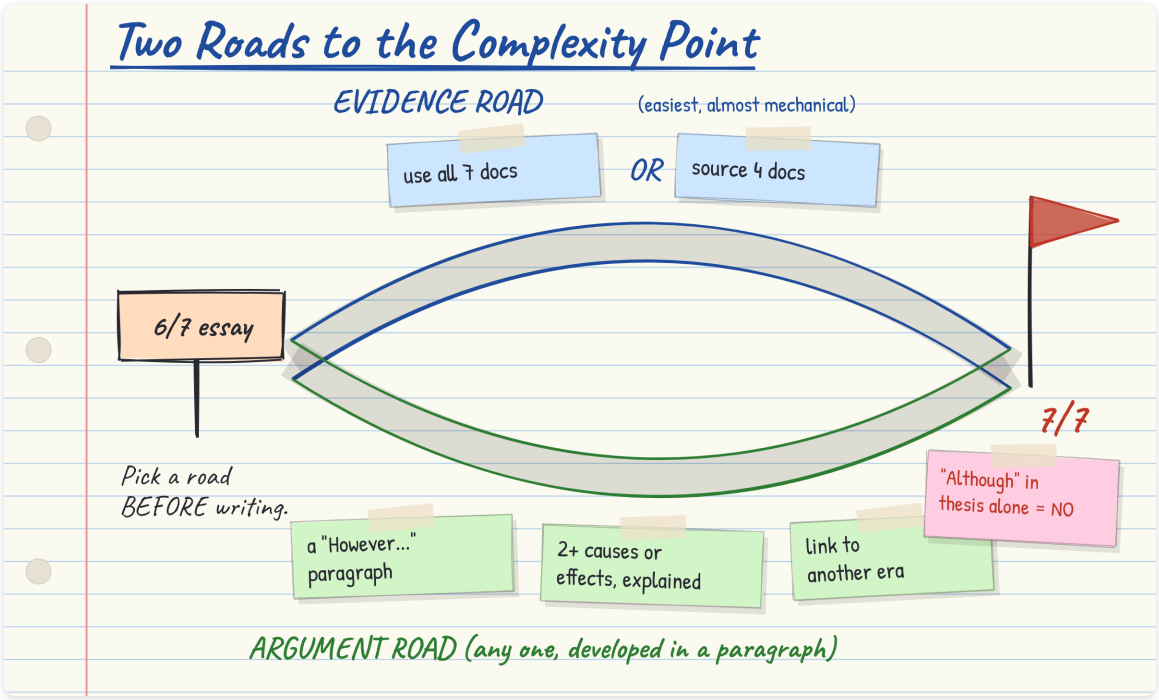
Two limits apply to every route:

- **It must be part of the argument.** A connection or counterpoint tossed in without explanation doesn't count.
- **It must be more than a phrase.** "Although some disagreed…" in the thesis alone doesn't earn it. The idea has to be developed somewhere in the essay, though it doesn't have to run throughout.

In the samples, all six 7-point essays earned it, and only one essay below 7 did (2024 Set 1 Sample 1B, by using all seven documents). It is the hardest point, but the evidence routes make it reachable mechanically.

The foolproof formula

Aim at **two routes at once**, so if a reader rejects one, the other carries the point.



Route 1, the evidence route (mechanical): do one of these.

1. **Use all seven documents**, each with a D-E-C sentence set (Guide 3). 2024 Set 1 Sample 1B earned complexity this way with zero sourcing.
2. **Source four documents** with HIPP (Guides 5A–5D). Each must tie to the argument; 2024 Set 2 Sample 1C fell short when its fourth sourcing didn't.

Route 2, the argument route (one planned paragraph): build the essay around a qualification.

1. **Thesis with "Although…"** (Guide 1). This signals the complexity but doesn't earn it alone.
2. **Body paragraphs 1–2** argue the main claim.
3. **Body paragraph 3 is the "However" paragraph.** Argue the other side, a limit, a continuity, or a different group's experience, with at least two documents.
4. **The last sentence of that paragraph explains the tension:** "This shows that [main claim] is true for [group/period], but [limit] for [other group/period], so [topic] changed only to a [limited] extent."
5. **Optional: a cross-period link in the conclusion.** Two or three sentences comparing the prompt's development to another era, with what the comparison reveals.

Cold War DBQ "However" paragraph frame (written for this guide):

- **Main claim:** federal programs (highways, education funding, containment abroad) reassured Americans the nation was prepared.
- **However:** the same government also fed fear — McCarthy's investigations (Doc A's "unwise investigators") and the nuclear arms race Kennedy calls a "balance of terror" (Doc E).
- **Tension sentence:** "The government's efforts calmed fears of falling behind the Soviets but deepened fears of nuclear war and of subversion at home, so its response was only partly effective."
- **Cross-period link:** compare the 1950s Red Scare to the First Red Scare of 1919–1920 and what each shows about how Americans react to perceived foreign threats.

Examples that earned the point

Source	Route	What was credited
2025 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Four sourced + cross-period connection	Sourced Docs 3, 4, 5, 7, and the last paragraph developed “an extended comparison” between the 1932–1980 debate over government's economic role and the same debate in the early republic.
2025 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Multiple effects + seven documents	Argued economic change both improved and harmed society (unity and lower prices vs. class division, poverty, racism), using all seven docs.
2024 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Four sourced + cross-period/region connection	Sourced four docs and compared the treatment of enslaved people in the U.S. to the treatment of Native Americans under early Spanish colonists.
2024 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 6)	Seven documents	Used all seven docs to support an argument, and earned complexity despite earning **no** sourcing point.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Four sourced	Historical situation for Docs 1, 2, 3, and 6, each tied to the argument.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Continuity and change	Argued citizenship expanded, then qualified it: for women and African Americans, discrimination continued and their citizenship essentially did not change.
2023 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Multiple perspectives and regions	Corroborated across themes (Mexican-American War, Second Great Awakening, market revolution) and regions (North, South, West).

College Board model descriptions (2025 guidelines):

- *Multiple perspectives:* argue that liberalism expanded the federal role and later produced a conservative backlash, then qualify that programs like Social Security stayed popular anyway.
- *Across regions:* argue that federal spending affected regions differently, from Northern and Western cities in the New Deal to the rise of the Sunbelt.

Examples that did not earn the point

Source	What happened
2024 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 3)	Tried the four-sourced route, but the Doc 5 purpose didn't support an argument, so only three counted.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	Sourced three documents and used five, but “does not attempt to explain how the evidence corroborates, qualifies, or modifies the argument.” Close on every route, but no route finished.
2025 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 5)	Sourced three documents and used four, but made “no attempt at sophisticated argumentation or effective use of evidence.” One more sourced document would likely have earned it.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	Full evidence marks (four docs + outside), but no sourcing and no qualification.
2023 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 4)	Thesis opened with “While some may claim that commercial development did not change American society unti[l] the gilded age…” but the counterclaim was never developed. A phrase in the thesis is not complexity.

Cold War non-examples (written for this guide):

- “The Cold War was very complex and had many sides.” Says complexity; doesn't show it.
- A conclusion that adds “This is like the War on Terror” with no explanation. A connection must be developed and tied to the argument.
- Six of seven documents used well. Close, but the seven-document route requires an attempt at all seven.

Expert tips

The two "most straightforward" routes taught by experienced AP readers match Route 1 above:

- **All seven documents:** "It doesn't have to be fancy, it doesn't have to be elegant." Do for all seven what you did for four.
- **Source four instead of two:** same skill, two more times.

A formula essay (context + thesis, Topic → Evidence → Analysis paragraphs, two sourced docs, one outside example) reliably earns 6 of 7. One of the two routes above adds the seventh.

Two more points:

- **One paragraph can carry it.** The essay doesn't have to be complex throughout; a well-built paragraph is enough for the argument routes.
- **Start in the thesis.** A thesis with a counterargument, or one that takes a minority position and backs it with categories, is on its way to earning the complexity point. As 2023 Set 1 Sample 1B shows, the counterclaim must then be developed in the body.

Grader checklist

Check the evidence routes first (they're countable), then the argument routes.

1. Are all seven documents used to support an argument (one or two may be weaker)? → **1 point**
2. Are four documents sourced, each tied to the argument? → **1 point**
3. Is there a developed qualification, counterargument, or second perspective, explained with evidence? → **1 point**
4. Are multiple causes or effects, or both continuity and change, explained (not just listed)? → **1 point**
5. Is there a developed comparison to another period or region that sharpens the argument? → **1 point**
6. Do documents and outside evidence together show how different groups saw the issue? → **1 point**

Any one = 1 point. If none, check whether the essay *gestures* at one; that's the best feedback target.

Feedback stems for students

- Close on documents: "You used [n] of 7 documents well. Add the remaining [n] to reach the seven-document route."
- Close on sourcing: "You sourced [n] documents. Two more fully sourced documents would earn complexity."
- Counterclaim not developed: "Your thesis says 'Although…' but the essay never comes back to it. Give that idea its own paragraph with two documents."